In Remembrance - A Holocaust Collection

By Elie Wiesel, William Heyen and Tawnysha Lynch

Never Shall I Forget by Eli Wiesel (Pg 34)

Never shall I forget that night, the first night in camp, that
turned my life into one long night seven times sealed.
Never shall I forget that smoke.
Never shall I forget the small faces of the children whose
bodies I saw transformed into smoke under a silent sky.
Never shall I forget those flames that consumed my faith
forever.
Never shall I forget the nocturnal silence that deprived me
for all eternity of the desire to live.
Never shall I forget those moments that murdered my God
and my soul and turned my dreams to ashes.
Never shall I forget those things, even were I condemned to
live as long as God Himself.
Never.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Eli Wiesel
Book: Night, Pg 34
ISBN: 978-0374500016
Publisher: Hill and Wang
Date (Month/Year): Jan 2006

INTRODUCTION

*Through their poetry **Never Shall I Forget** by Elie Wiesel, **A Visit to Belzec** and **To the Onlookers** by William Heyen and **As the Orchestra Played** by Tawnysha Lynch, shallow graves are unearthed and the tortured souls of six million who perished during the Holocaust are honored.*

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A Visit to Belzec by William Heyen (Pg 86-89)

I

This is Belzec,
in the East of Poland,
in the Lublin region
where the fumes of Sobibor,
Maidenek, and Treblinka still
stain the air:
smell the bodies
in the factories' smoke,
smell the sweet gas

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in the clover and grass.
This is Belzec
where the death compound's gate
proclaims in Hebrew,
«Welcome to the Jewish State.»
This is Belzec.
This is SS humor.
Curse them forever
in their black Valhalla.

II

At 7:20 a.m. a train arrived from Lemberg with 45 wagons holding more than 6,000 people. Of these, 1,450 were already dead on arrival. Behind the small, barbed-wire windows, children, young ones, frightened to death, women and men. As the train drew in, 200 Ukrainians detailed for the task tore open the doors and, laying about them with their leather whips, drove the Jews out of the cars. Instructions boomed from a loudspeaker, ordering them to remove all clothing, artificial limbs, and spectacles. . . They asked what was going to happen to them. . . Most of them knew the truth. The odor told them what their fate was to be. They walked up a small flight of steps and into the death chambers, most of them without a word, thrust forward by those behind them.

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III

Listener, you have walked
into the smoke-streaked mirror
of my dream, but I can't,
or won't remember.
Did my jackboots gleam?
Did I fill out quotas?
Was it before, or after?
Did I close those doors,
or did I die?
I can still feel
iron and cold water on my fingers,
I remember running
along the bank of a river,
under trees with full summer
stars in their branches,
the sky lit up with flares
and the slight murderous arcs of tracers,
the night air wet
with the sugary odors of leaves.

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Dogs barked.
Were they mine?
Were they yours?
Was I running from,
or after?

IV

Inside the chambers SS men were crushing the people
together. `Fill them up well -- 700 or 800 of them to every
270 square feet.' Now the doors were closed. . .
The bodies were tossed out, blue, wet with sweat and urine,
the legs soiled with feces and menstrual blood. A couple of
dozen workers checked the mouths of the dead, which they
tore open with iron hooks. Other workers inspected anus
and genital organs in search of money, diamonds, gold;
dentists moved around hammering out gold teeth, bridges
and crowns. . .

V

Listener, all words are a dream,
You have wandered into mine.
Now, as workers rummage among the corpses,
we will leave for our affairs.

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This happened only once, but happened:
one Belzec morning, a boy in deathline
composed a poem, and spoke it.
The words seemed true, and saved him.
The guard's mouth fell open to wonder.
We have walked together
into the smoke-streaked
terror of Belzec,
and have walked away.
Now wind,
and the dawn sun,
lift our meeting
to where they lift the human haze
above that region's pines.

To The Onlookers by William Heyen (Pg 39)

When our backs are turned,
when someone stares at us,
we feel them.
You who watched the killing, and did nothing,
still feel the eyes of those dead
on your bodies.

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How many see you
as you pick a violet?
How many oak branches twist
into hands begging for help?
How many memories congeal
in the sun's evening blood?
O the unsung cradlesongs
in the dove's nightcries--
so many would have loved
their own stars in the night skies,
but now only the old well
can do it for them.
You did not murder,
but looked on, you,
who could have been changed
into light.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: William Heyen
Book: Erika: Poems of the Holocaust, Pgs 86-89; 39
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Publisher: Time Being Books
Date (Month/Year): June 1991

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As the Orchestra Played by Tawnysha Lynch

Summoned to Auschwitz's doors,
I could hear the violin's mournful voice
Calling to me as I entered history's largest grave
As the orchestra played.

When life's selections took place,
I could hear the drum's rhythmic pace
Chronicling our short life's goodbye
As the orchestra played.

When I became a prisoner,
I could hear the clarinet's fluid notes
Mocking at what I have become
As the orchestra played.

When I sorted through the evidence of martyrdom,
I could hear the guitar's music
Allowing my mind to escape
As the orchestra played.

When beaten without reason,
I could hear the trumpet's shout

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Announcing each crippling blow
As the orchestra played.

When I dug graves for my brethren,
I could hear the bass' low hum
Predicting the horror to come
As the orchestra played.

When train loads of people perished in gas chambers,
I could hear the bagpipe's chilling song
Forever haunting their frozen, blackened faces
As the orchestra played.

When I saw massacred skeletons wither away in ovens,
I could hear the cello's sorrowful tune
Lamenting a bitter cry
As the orchestra played.

When I struggled to survive,
I could hear the flute sing
Telling of my affliction
As the orchestra played.

When I was chosen to die,
I could hear the accordion's melody

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Foretelling my fate
As the orchestra played.

When my essence exhaled its last,
I could hear the harmonica
Proclaiming my life's departure
As the orchestra played.

When my ashes drifted from the grave,
I could hear the instruments join as one
Bidding me farewell
As the orchestra played.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Tawnysha Lynch
Book: Remembrance
ISBN: 978-1891231575
Publisher: Word Association Publishers
Date (Month/Year): 2001
Also On-line at
http://rihsenglish.pbworks.com/w/page/6787302/Poems

(Echo from Never Shall I Forget)

Never shall I forget those things, even were I condemned to live as long as God Himself.

Never.

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CLOSING

*But we must do more than just **remember**. Elie Weisel tried to explain in his Nobel Peace Prize speech in 1986: "When human lives are endangered, when human dignity is in jeopardy, national borders and sensitivities become irrelevant. Wherever men or women are persecuted because of their race, religion, or political views, that place must – at that moment – become the center of the universe."*

Can we stop the world from falling apart? Gaza, Sudan, Ukraine, Myanmar, Ethiopia, Haiti. The list of global conflicts grows longer; while here in the US we face our own divisions of race, religion and politics.

We must do more than just remember. Think higher, feel deeper, do more. Donate to a food bank, help your neighbor, volunteer, vote in all the elections. Be a part of the solution, not part of the problem.

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